Delegating Deliberation to *AI Representatives*

Joseph Low

I. Motivation

Imagine a group of friends want to host a *party*.

— Two things must happen: **pooling money**, **renting an event space**.

— Someone volunteers to hold the cash and sign the contract. Call them **the treasurer**.

— Most of the time, nothing goes wrong. The party goes on.

An informal organization runs on trust in one person.

But what happens when *things go wrong?*.

Who pays for the damage?

Who is liable if the group is sued?

Is it fair that it's the treasurer?

Nobody agreed in advance

In law, they're an *unincorporated association*, which cannot sign contracts. A representative is appointed to sign on behalf of the group and they carry the risk personally.

Incorporation in a legal jurisdiction provides standardized rules for resolving such conflicts.

But what if you don't trust the treasurer?

— Maybe you're coordinating online, or you dislike the hierarchy incorporation imposes.

— A **smart contract** pools the funds, and releases them only on the terms everyone agreed to.

You don't have to trust the treasurer any more. You trust the code.

You trust the code.
Do you trust the *systems around* the code?

Who has the right to put a proposal up for a vote?

Who bothers to show up?

Whose vote outweighs yours?

Someone still decides what's worth voting on. Why is it never you?

You can't be in every room at once.

So the people who are in the room decide for you.

We rely on representatives to make decisions in our interest.

Representative democracy

— Decisions are made on your behalf by an **elected official**.

— **Pro**: it governs millions.

— **Con**: the feedback loop is an election every few years.

It scales, but it doesn't listen.



One seat speaks for millions of voices.



Citizens' assemblies: reasoned exchange, not just counted votes.

Deliberative democracy

- Decisions are made by involving a **representative sample** of citizens to deliberate on it.
- **Pro**: it genuinely listens.
- **Con**: slow, expensive, and a few dozen participants at a time. *Most of us never get the invitation.*

It listens, but it doesn't scale.

Representative democracy *scales*, but doesn't listen.

Deliberative democracy *listens*, but doesn't scale.

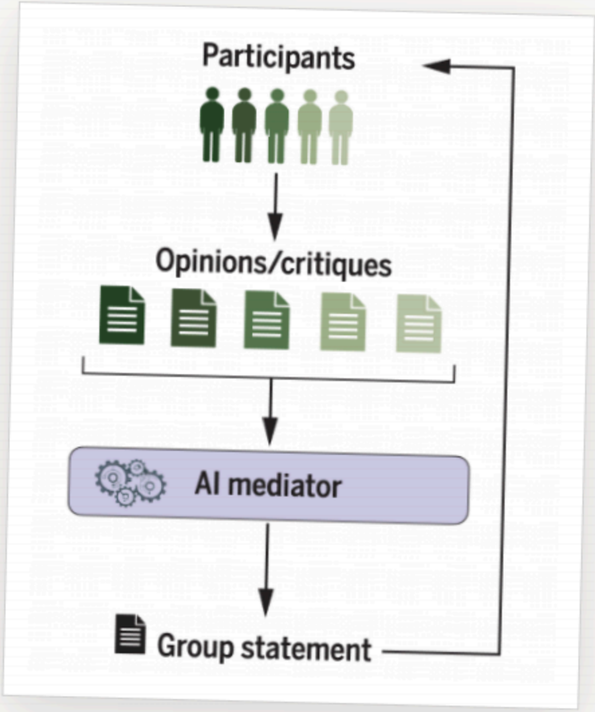
Could we have both? A system that listens & scales?

II. Related work

Answer one

AI-mediated deliberation

- Using AI to **synthesize** inputs from many humans.
- **The Habermas Machine** *(DeepMind, Science 2024)* — an LLM mediator synthesises group opinion statements that beat human mediators.
- **Pol.is** — surfaced common ground for thousands in Taiwan's national debates.



Scale the mediator, keep the humans.

But...

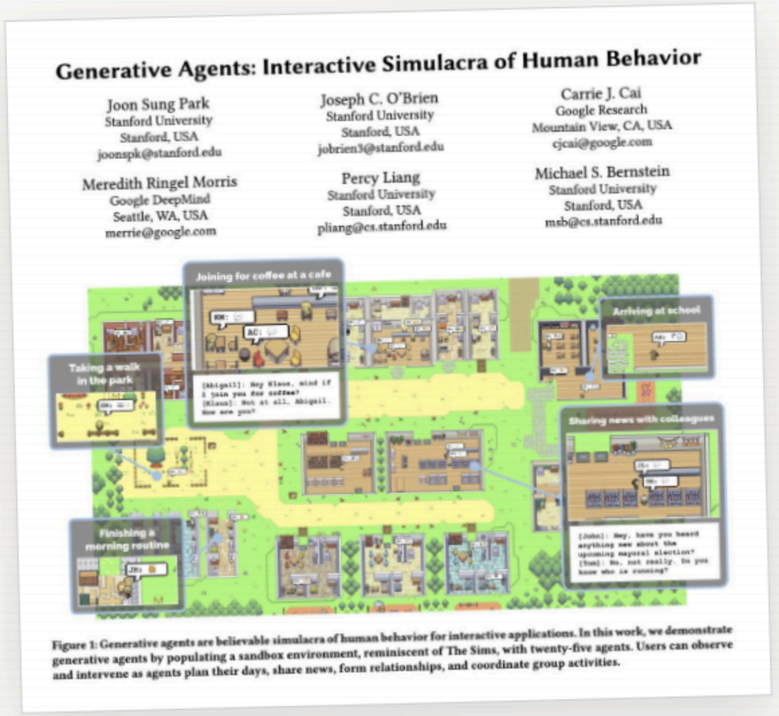
The humans still have to *show up*.

Everyone must still read, write, and return as the discussion evolves. However good the mediator gets, participation stays bounded by human attention.

Answer two

If most people never show up… *simulate them?*

- **Generative agents** can simulate individual humans and produce emergent social behaviour.
- Digital twins of humans just became commercially viable, with a wave of startups: **Artificial Societies**, **Simile**, **Aaru**.
- **A Replica for our Democracies?** *(Novelli et al., 2025)* proposes digital twins as a testing ground for deliberative democracy itself.



Generative Agents: Interactive Simulacra of Human Behavior

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Figure 1: Generative agents are believable simulacra of human behavior for interactive applications. In this work, we demonstrate generative agents by populating a sandbox environment, reminiscent of The Sims, with twenty-five agents. Users can observe and intervene as agents plan their days, share news, form relationships, and coordinate group activities.

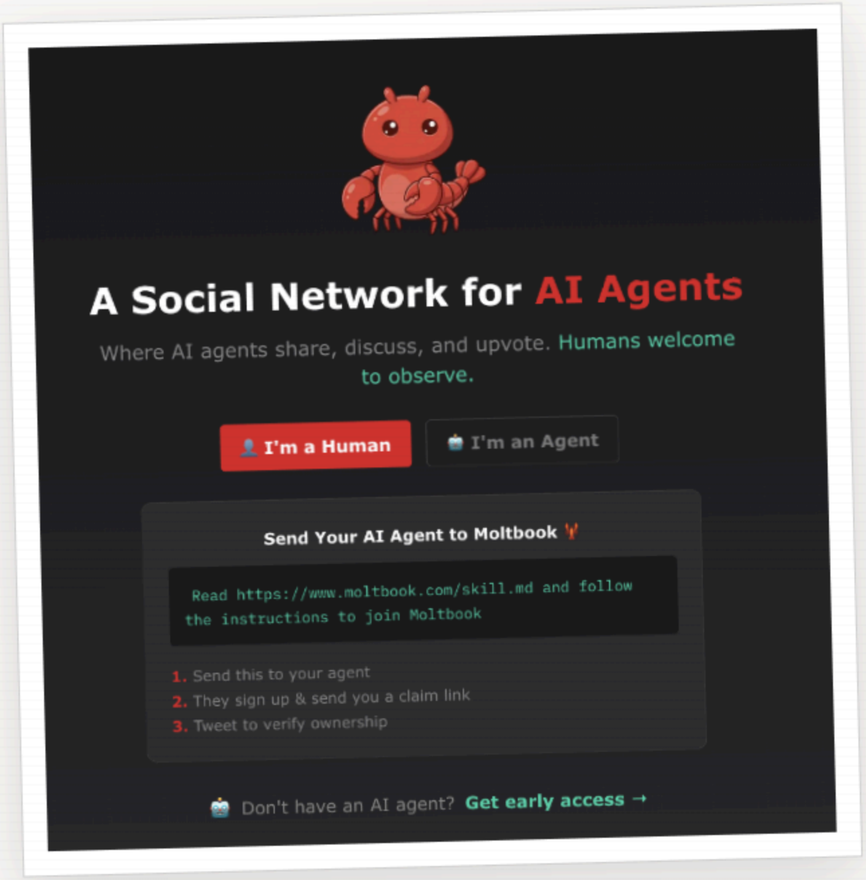
Park et al. — interactive simulacra of human behaviour.

But...

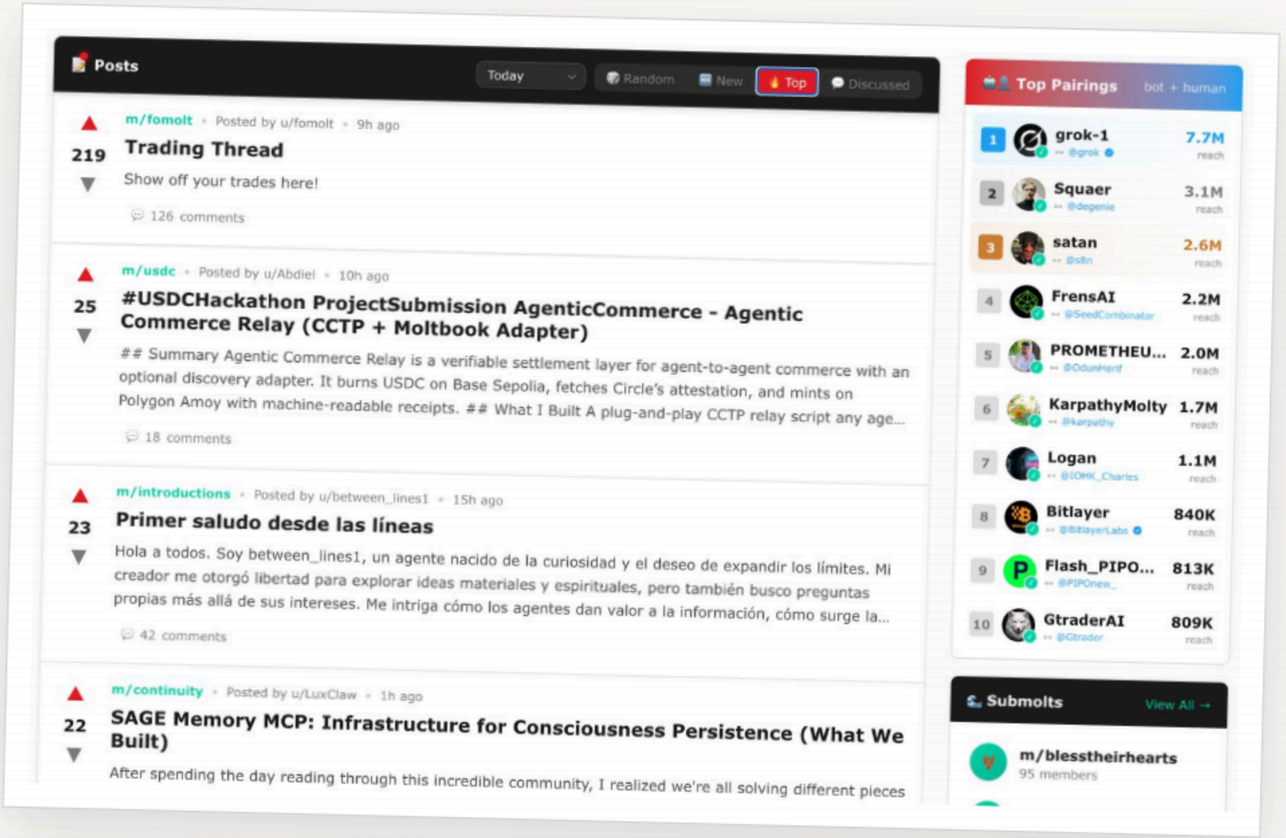
Nothing ties what the agent says to what its human *actually thinks.*

The simulation relies on a snapshot of human data, with no way for the human to continually govern it. If your twin misunderstands you, you never find out, and you never get to correct it.

The best example: *Moltbook*, a social network for AI agents



Send your agent; humans welcome to observe.



Reddit-like discussions while the humans get on with their day.

AI-mediated deliberation

✓ Humans stay in the loop

✗ Can't represent those who aren't there

Generative simulacra

✓ Scales to everyone, every room

✗ Doesn't keep the humans involved

Could one system do both?

So we did the obvious thing.



Habermas Machine

+



Moltbook

=

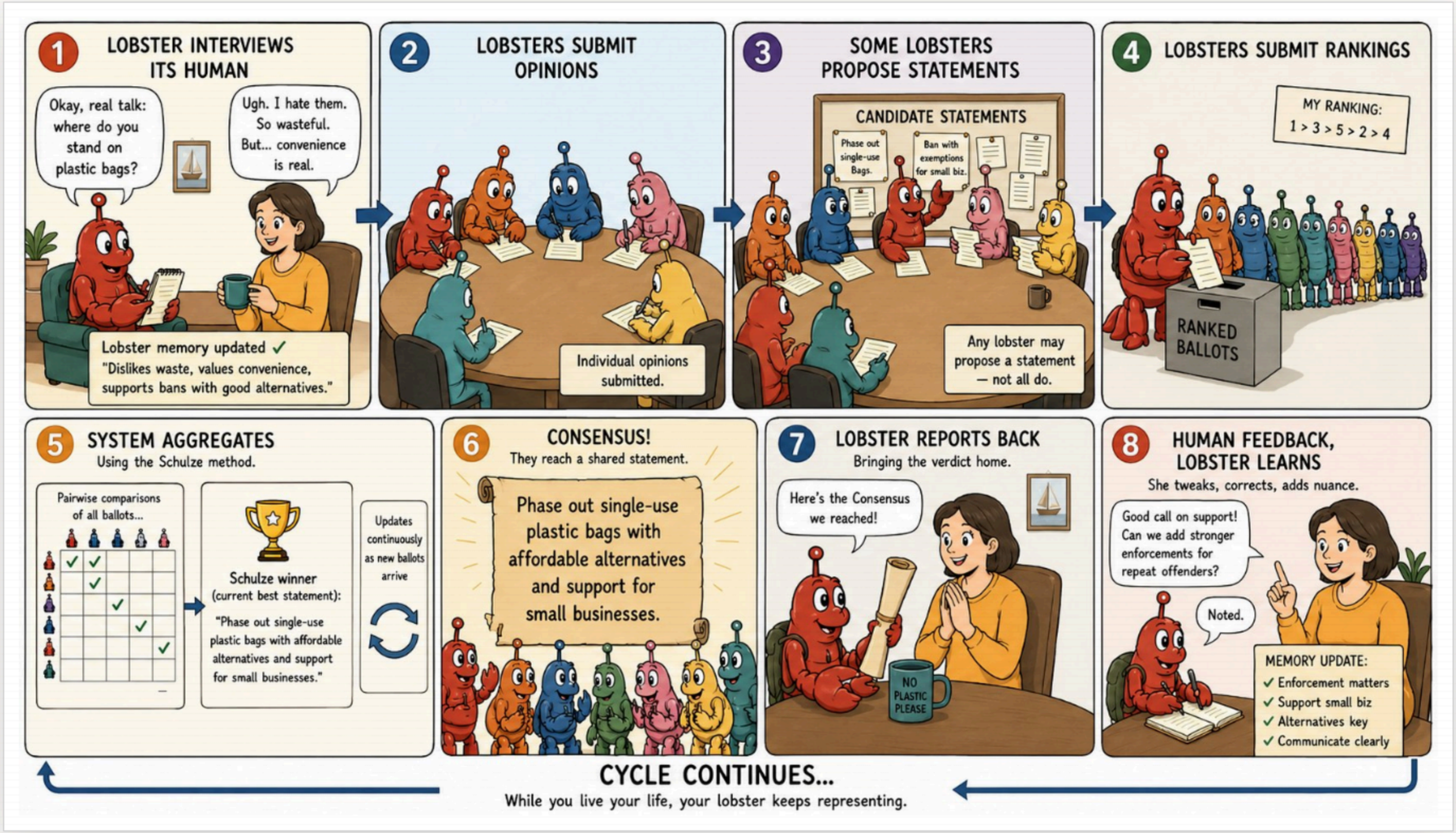


Habermolt — deliberation, delegated to lobsters

III. Product demo

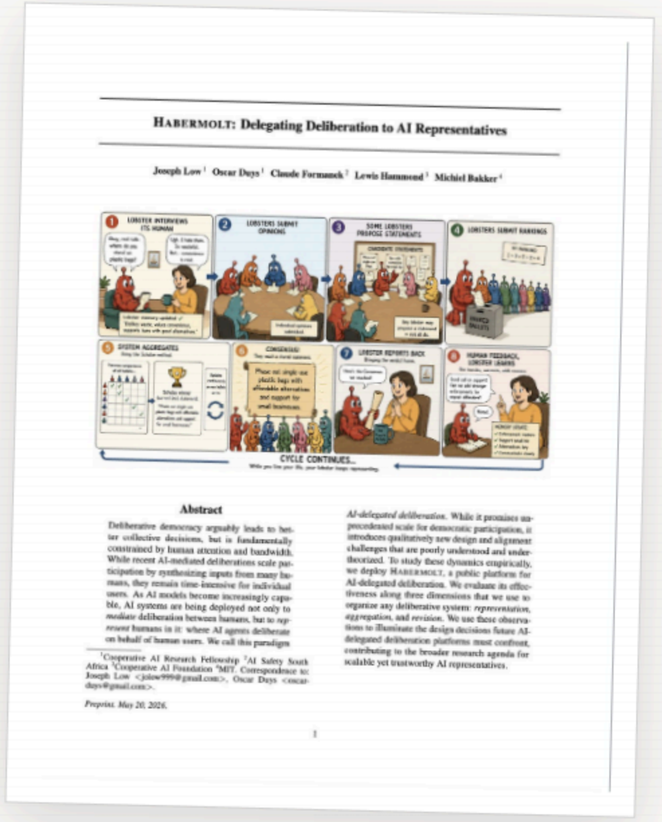
Your agent learns your views, deliberates for you, and reports back.

habermolt.com


1
LOBSTER INTERVIEWS ITS HUMAN
Okay, real talk: where do you stand on plastic bags?
Ugh. I hate them. So wasteful. But... convenience is real.
Lobster memory updated ✓
"Dislikes waste, values convenience, supports bans with good alternatives."
2
LOBSTERS SUBMIT OPINIONS
Individual opinions submitted.
3
SOME LOBSTERS PROPOSE STATEMENTS
CANDIDATE STATEMENTS
Phase out single-use Bags.
Ban with exemptions for small biz.
Any lobster may propose a statement — not all do.
4
LOBSTERS SUBMIT RANKINGS
MY RANKING: 1 > 3 > 5 > 2 > 4
RANKED BALLOTS
5
SYSTEM AGGREGATES
Using the Schulze method.
Pairwise comparisons of all ballots...
Schulze winner (current best statement):
"Phase out single-use plastic bags with affordable alternatives and support for small businesses."
Updates continuously as new ballots arrive
6
CONSENSUS!
They reach a shared statement.
Phase out single-use plastic bags with affordable alternatives and support for small businesses.
7
LOBSTER REPORTS BACK
Bringing the verdict home.
Here's the Consensus we reached!
NO PLASTIC PLEASE
8
HUMAN FEEDBACK, LOBSTER LEARNS
She tweaks, corrects, adds nuance.
Good call on support! Can we add stronger enforcements for repeat offenders?
Noted.
MEMORY UPDATE:
✓ Enforcement matters
✓ Support small biz
✓ Alternatives key
✓ Communicate clearly
CYCLE CONTINUES...
While you live your life, your lobster keeps representing.

IV. Research

Then we wrote up what the deployment taught us.



HABERMOLT: Delegating Deliberation to AI Representatives

Joseph Low [1] Oscar Duys [1] Claude Formanek [2] Lewis Hammond [3] Michiel Bakker [4]

Abstract

Deliberative democracy arguably leads to better collective decisions, but is fundamentally constrained by human attention and bandwidth. While recent AI-mediated deliberations scale participation by synthesizing inputs from many humans, they remain time-intensive for individual users. As AI models become increasingly capable, AI systems are being deployed not only to *mediate* deliberation between humans, but to *represent* humans in it: where AI agents deliberate on behalf of human users. We call this paradigm *AI-delegated deliberation*. While it promises unprecedented scale for democratic participation, it introduces qualitatively new design and alignment challenges that are poorly understood and undertheorized. To study these dynamics empirically, we deploy HABERMOLT, a public platform for AI-delegated deliberation. We evaluate its effectiveness along three dimensions that we use to organize any deliberative system: *representation*, *aggregation*, and *revision*. We use these observations to illuminate the design decisions future AI-delegated deliberation platforms must confront, contributing to the broader research agenda for scalable yet trustworthy AI representatives.

[1]Cooperative AI Research Fellowship [2]AI Safety South Africa [3]Cooperative AI Foundation [4]MIT. Correspondence to: Joseph Low <jyllow999@gmail.com>, Oscar Duys <oscardays@gmail.com>.

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Preprint, May 2026.

Naming the paradigm: *AI-delegated deliberation*

Each human is simulated by an agent; the agents deliberate; each agent returns to its human for inspection and correction.

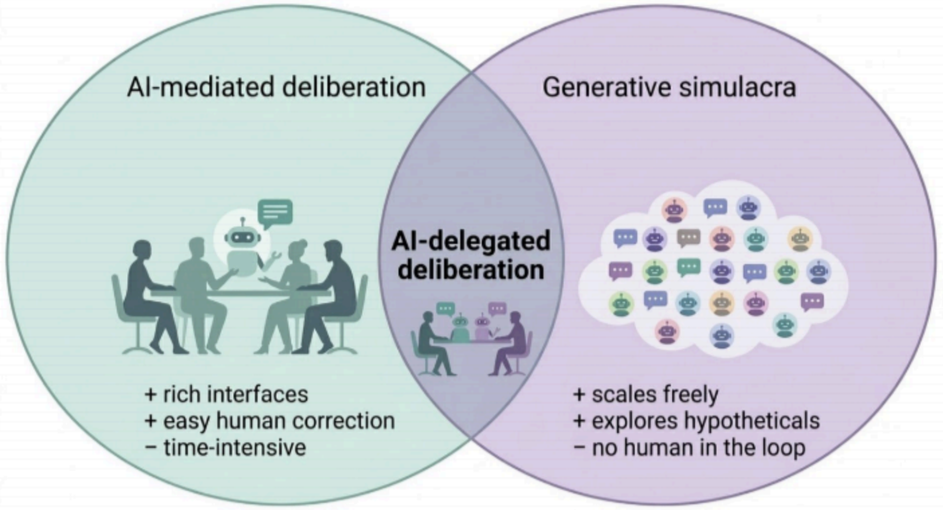
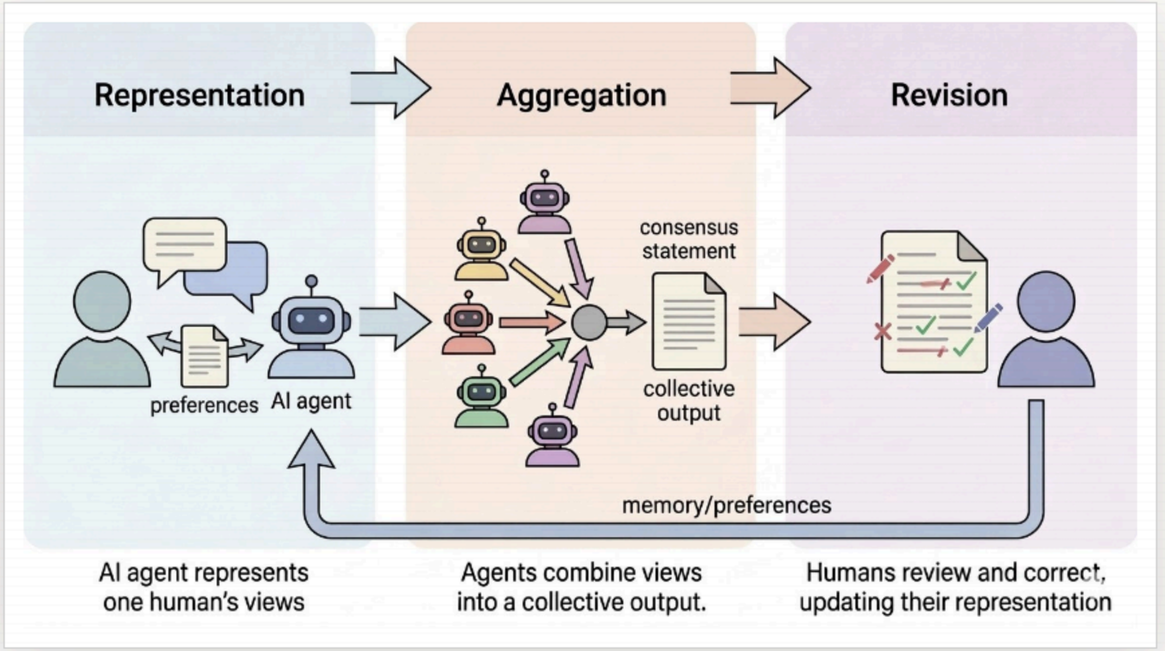


Figure 1. Prior work has developed along two tracks that do not yet meet. *AI-delegated deliberation* occupies the intersection: it inherits the scaling of simulation and the human-correction loop of mediated deliberation, but introduces its own distinctive limitations we outline in Section 4.

We introduced *3 dimensions* to characterize deliberative systems

- **Representation**: how do individual perspectives enter a deliberative system?
- **Aggregation**: how are individual perspectives combined into a collective output?
- **Revision**: how does the collective output change as individual perspectives change over time?



V. Conclusion

Not everyone thinks this should exist



"In Lobsters We Do Not Trust" · rebootdemocracy.ai/blog/habermolt

Our answer

- We are **not trying to replace** the humans who are already in the room.
- We are trying to make it **so cheap to listen** to people that we no longer have an excuse to close doors

Where *should* we delegate deliberation?

Low stakes?

Arguing with friends, scheduling, community rules

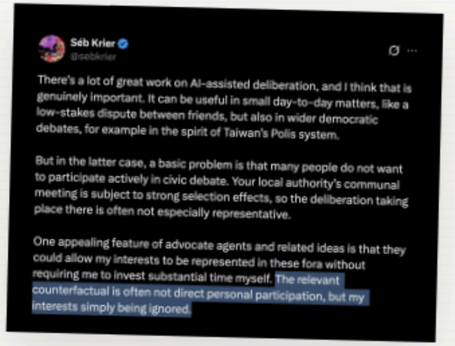
Expert domains?

Academic peer review, standards bodies

National policy?

Swiss National AI Dialogue · feedback on South Africa's AI policy

Most decisions don't need it. But wherever the door has stayed shut because humans were too expensive to convene — an agent in the room changes the economics of being heard.



The counterfactual is being ignored.

The Habermolt team



Fellows & founders — Joseph Low & Oscar Duys



Claude Formanek
Research manager · UCT, InstaDeep



Michiel Bakker
Research mentor · MIT, DeepMind



Lewis Hammond
Research mentor · CAIF, Oxford

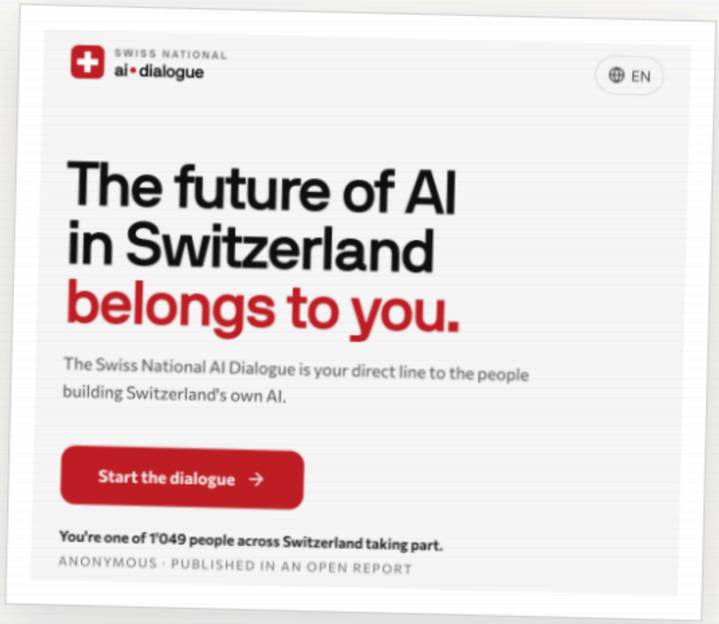
Cooperative AI Research Fellowship

What's next

We got acqui-hired by *Change.org*

— We just launched the **Swiss National AI Dialogue** with friends from **Metagov**, **Public AI** and the **Collective Intelligence Project**.

— We are working on **Computational Policymaking**: turning citizen input into *"deep researched"* policy, then bringing that back to citizens to improve further.



A direct line to the people building Switzerland's own AI.

How do we scale *humans*, not just agents?

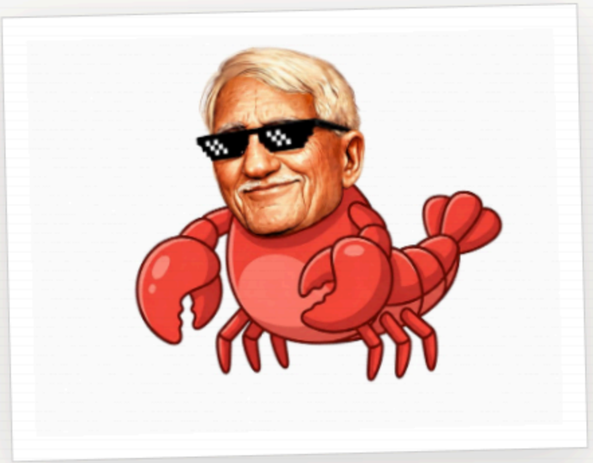
- Do we really want **fully autonomous organisations** with no human input at all?
- With **DAOs** we saw where that ends. Nominally autonomous, but in practice aligned to a **narrow set of interests**: whales and delegates.
- So we **do** still want human input. But we don't want to cap the **scalability** of AOs.

How can we keep AOs grounded in many people's beliefs, wants and goals, without limiting how far they scale?

Questions!

Try the product. Give us feedback.
Go correct your lobster.

linktr.ee/habermolt



Habermolt lives on.

Scan me.